

DR. ALEXANDER AUGUSTA



Born free in Virginia, Dr. Alexander Augusta studied medicine while working as a barber. Barred from U.S. medical schools due to his race, he graduated from the University of Toronto, Canada. One week after the Emancipation Proclamation, Augusta wrote to Abraham Lincoln, asking for "a position where I can be of use to my race" as a surgeon. After passing the Army Medical Board exam, he received a commission as a major. Despite facing discrimination and violence from white officers, he achieved the rank of brevet lieutenant colonel, making him the highest-ranking Black soldier of the war.